

A WARM WELCOME Rubio meets foreign minister S. Jaishankar at the Taj Mahal Palace hotel, Mumbai, Oct. 20

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over Ukraine. New Delhi countered that affordable and reliable energy was a national necessity, especially for an economy serving more than 1.4 billion people. The Iran conflict and disruptions to shipping through the Strait of Hormuz and Red Sea have dramatically altered that calculation. With global energy supplies under pressure, Washington has temporarily relaxed certain restrictions affecting Russian oil flows, mainly because rising diesel prices could affect the Republican Party's chances in the US mid-term polls.

Rubio's explanation was strikingly pragmatic. American foreign policy, he argued, had to consider the global economic consequences of its decisions rather than judge every issue through the lens of a single conflict. More importantly, he reframed Washington's expectations of India. The objective was no longer to make India buy less Russian crude. It was to encourage India to buy more American, Venezuelan and other western hemisphere oil. He even acknowledged that India's efforts to diversify its energy portfolio were driven by its own interests, rather than American threats.

There is a critical qualification, though. Rubio did not offer India a permanent exemption from Russian oil sanctions. The temporary relaxation reflects the pressures of an extraordinary global energy situation. His visit to Reliance's Jamnagar refinery fitted directly into this emerging strategy. Rubio praised the facility's scale and sophistication and linked it to Reliance's investment in refining capacity at Brownsville, Texas, which he hoped would be operational by 2029.

A BALANCING ACT

On Pakistan, the limits of Washington's accommodation were more evident. Islamabad's military leadership has regained its diplomatic relevance in Washington, particularly with its role in regional diplomacy involving Iran. For India, which has long sought to predicate its strategic partnership with America on a clearer gap in the latter's bilateral ties with Pakistan, this renewed engagement is unsettling. Rubio sought to reassure New Delhi, but without retreating from US policy. "In no way does the relationship with Pakistan come at the expense of our relationship with India," he said. He argued that engagement with Islamabad increased Washington's ability to influence Pakistani decisions, while emphasising that the US shared India's concerns about terrorism.

On defence, Gor emphasised continuity, pointing to the presence of US manufacturers such as Lockheed Martin and Boeing in India, ongoing co-production, joint military exercises and the participation of advanced American aircraft in exercises with Indian forces. His argument was that defence cooperation had already moved far beyond a conventional buyer-seller relationship. Joint training and industrial partnerships were creating a level of familiarity and trust that would have been difficult to imagine two decades ago. Yet it's still shy of India's central demand of deeper technology transfer and genuine joint development.

The more substantial strategic issues concerned the Quad grouping. Rubio identified secure supply chains as a central objective. But rather than explicitly framing the initiative as a campaign against China, he argued that neither India nor America should depend excessively on any single country for critical products and technologies.

The sharpest reminder that national interests still diverge came over H-1B visas and skilled immigration. The Trump administration's higher visa costs and tighter restrictions have created considerable anxiety among Indian workers, employers and students. Asked how America could seek closer technology cooperation while making it harder for Indian professionals to work there, Rubio offered no special dispensation. The changes, he insisted, were global rather than directed against India.

The larger significance of the INDIA TODAY interview lies in what it reveals about the changing terms of India-US engagement. The relationship is no longer sustained simply by shared strategic aspirations or the personal friendship between its leaders. Increasingly, it is being judged by whether the two sides can deliver tangible benefits to each other. ■